

ABEKA SCHOLAR ACADEMY

Subj Grade 8 Grammar & Composition Curriculum

Official Curriculum & Study Material

Chapter 1

Welcome to our amazing journey into grammar & composition! We have so many fun things to discover today. Let's get started! Did you know? Grammar is the study of words, how they are used in sentences, and how they change in different situations. The Ancient Greeks used to call it *grammatikè tékhnē* the craft of letters. It can have any of these meanings: The study of a language: how it works, and everything about it. This is background research on language.

Let me tell you a fascinating story. The study of sentence structure. Rules and examples show how the language should be used. This is a correct usage grammar, as in a textbook or manual/guide. The system which people learn as they grow up. This is the native-speaker's grammar. Let me tell you a fascinating story. When we speak, we use the native person's grammar, or as near as we can. When we write, we try to write with correct grammar. So, speaking and writing a language each have their own style.

All languages have their own grammar. Most European languages are rather similar. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! English makes few changes to its word endings ('suffixes'). In Romance languages (such as French, Italian, and Spanish), word endings carry a lot of meaning. In English we have just a few: plurals and possessives (John's) are the most common. In our verbs we have dropped most endings except one: I love, you love, but she loves. That final 's' comes from the Anglo-Saxon, which had more suffixes. Verbs do have endings which show changes in tense: walked, walking. Word order is the other big difference. Romance languages normally put adjectives after the nouns to which they refer. For example, in English, a person may say I like fast cars, but in Spanish, it is *Me gustan los coches rápidos*. The order of the words has changed: if just the words, without the grammar, are translated into English, it would mean 'to me they please the cars fast'. This is because Spanish and English have different rules about word order. In German, verbs often come near the end of sentences (as: *Die Katze hat das Futter gegessen*), whereas in English we usually put them between subject and object, as: the cat has eaten the food.

Written grammar changes slowly but spoken grammar is more fluid. Sentences which English speakers find normal today, might have seemed strange 100 years ago. And they might not, because many of our favourite sayings come from the Authorized King James Version of the Bible, and from Shakespeare. Different people speak with grammar that differs from that of other people. For

example, people who use the dialects called General American English and BBC English might say, I didn't do anything, while someone who speaks what is called African American Vernacular English or AAVE might say, I didn't do nothing. London working class version: I ain't done nuffink! These are called double negatives, and are found almost entirely in spoken English, and seldom written. Did you know? These differences are called dialects. The dialect a person uses is usually decided by where they live. Even though the dialects of English use different words or word order, they still have grammar rules. However, when writing in American English, grammar uses the rules of General American English. When people talk about using 'proper English', they usually mean using the grammar of general British English, as described in standard reference works. The models for spoken English in Britain are often called Received Pronunciation or BBC English.

Grammar studies nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions, conjunctions, sentences, phrases, clauses and interjections. Nouns are 'thing' words like 'table' and 'chair'. They are objects, things you see in everyday life. Proper nouns are names of specific places, people, or other things like days of the week. The name 'James' is a proper noun, as is 'Wednesday' and 'London'. Nouns can also be abstract things, such as 'suffering' or 'happiness'. Let me tell you a fascinating story. Verbs are words that describe actions: "Ryan threw the ball". State: "I am worried". The basic verb form is called the infinitive. The infinitive for existence is "to be". A famous example is the speech of Hamlet: To be or not to be, that is the question.

Chapter 2

Adjectives describe nouns. For example, the pretty in "pretty bicycle" says that the bicycle is pretty. In other words, the "pretty" is describing the bicycle. This can also happen with a place. For example, the tall in "that's a tall building" is describing the building. Grammar studies syntax which is how the "parts of speech" fit together and create sentences. This is one of my favorite things to teach! English grammar is the grammar of the English language. Grammar is the rules about how to speak and write in a language. English grammar started with Old English, having a grammar similar to other West Germanic languages of the time. After Normandy conquered England in 1066, parts of the Latin language were brought to the English language by the Norman language.

Close your eyes and picture this... Dialects of English vary not only in pronunciation but in grammar too. For example, people who use what is called General American English or Received Pronunciation might say, "I didn't do anything," while someone who speaks what is called African

American Vernacular English might say, "I didn't do nothing," and a working class Londoner who speaks Cockney English might say, "I ain't done nuffink." The dialect a person speaks with is usually decided by where they live and their socioeconomic background. Even though the dialects of English use different words or word order, they still have grammar rules. However, when writing in American English, grammar uses the rules of General American English. When people talk about using "proper English", they usually mean using the grammar of general British English, as described in standard reference works. The models for spoken English in Britain are often called Received Pronunciation or BBC English. English makes few changes to its word endings. These are called ('suffixes'): plurals and possessives (John's) are the most common. English verbs drop most endings except one: I love, you love, they love, but she loves. That final 's' is a remnant of Anglo-Saxon, which had more suffixes. Verbs do have endings which show changes in tense: walked, walking.

Word order is the other big difference. In English, adjectives usually come before the noun. Most Romance languages normally put their adjectives after the nouns. For example, in English, a person may say I like fast cars, but in Spanish, it is Me gustan los coches rápidos [coches = cars; rápidos = fast]. The order of the words has changed: if just the words, without the grammar, are translated into English, it would mean 'to me they please the cars fast'. This is because Spanish and English have different rules about word order. In German, main verbs often come near the end of sentences, but in English we usually put them between subject and object, as: the cat sat on the mat. Grammar studies the different parts of language. The parts of language are called "parts of speech." The parts of speech are nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions, conjunctions, and interjections. A noun is a word that names something, such as a person, place, thing, or idea. They can be a single thing such as an apple. They can also be plural such as a box of apples. There is a special kind of noun called a proper noun, which is a name. For instance, Johnny Appleseed.

Pronouns are words that take the place of nouns. We often use them to avoid repeating the nouns that they refer to. An example is the word "it." In the sentence "I like the ball; it is blue," you have to look at what comes before "it" to know that "it" is talking about the ball. The noun before a pronoun that the pronoun really means is called the antecedent. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: There are different types of pronouns in English language. The most important ones are: The basic verb form is called the infinitive. The infinitive for existence is "to be". A famous example is the speech of Hamlet: to be or not to be?

Words that tell you about nouns are called adjectives. When an adjective is used, you learn more about the noun. An example would be the words "red" and "juicy" in the phrase "the red apple is juicy."

They do not have any endings. Even if the noun they talk about is plural, they stay the same. You can see this in the sentence "the red apples are juicy." There are two kinds of adjectives: definitive and descriptive. Definite adjectives are words like: the, a, this, that, these, those, my, thy, your, our, his, etc.. They are called determiners by some. Descriptive adjectives are the other ones like: red, green, blue, happy, sad, big, medium, small, little, etc. Adverbs are words that tell you about words that are not nouns. An adverb can describe a verb, like the word "quickly" in the sentence "He ran quickly." They can also describe an adjective. The adverb "very" describes the adjective "sick" in the sentence "The boy is very sick." Adverbs can even describe other adverbs, as in the sentence "He ran very quickly." A preposition is a word that describes how one noun (or pronoun) relates to another in the sentence as a whole. The preposition usually comes before the noun that it adds to the sentence, which is called the object of the preposition. An example is the word "over" in the sentence "he walked over the bridge."

Chapter 3

A conjunction is a word that connects other parts of a sentence. It can connect two words that both do the same thing in a sentence. "And" in the sentence "the boy and the girl run" connects the boy to the girl because they both run. Conjunctions can even connect two clauses that would normally be different sentences together. The word "but" in the sentence "I like cats, but he likes dogs" is a conjunction doing this. Interjections are words that do not fit normal grammar rules. Interjections can and often do take the place of an entire sentence, as they can give they meaning of a whole sentence in a single word. These can be used to show emotions, such as the word "Hooray," which means that the speaker is happy or likes something. They are also used to shorten common phrases that would otherwise need a full sentence to talk about. For example, saying the word "yes" is much simpler than saying "what you say is true," so it is usually used instead. Interjections like these can be helpful for saving time and making complex sentences very simple. Often, though, interjections may have no meaning at all, such as the word "um." Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Grammar also studies how the parts of language work together. This is called "syntax." Some common ways in which the words fit together are phrases, clauses, sentences, and paragraphs.

Analysis is the part of syntax that deals with the parts of a sentence called elements. There are two levels of elements: primary and secondary. The primary elements the subject and the predicate. The secondary elements are the parts of these. A clause is a group of word with a subject and predicate.

Clauses may either be principle or dependent. A dependent clause is a clause that acts as a part of another clause. Close your eyes and picture this... A sentence is a group of words with a complete meaning. Sentences must contain at least one principle clause.

This is one of my favorite things to teach! There are four kinds of sentences: Simple, Compound, Complex, and Compound Complex. A simple sentence is a sentence with one principle clause. A Compound sentence is a sentence with two or more principle sentences.

A Complex sentence is a sentence with at least one dependent clause. A compound complex sentence is one fitting the second and third definitions. Close your eyes and picture this... Construction is the part of syntax that deals with putting words together.

Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! The subject of a sentence may be a noun, a pronoun, an infinitive phrase, a gerund, and so on. An adjunct is a word, phrase, or clause that describes another thing. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! A noun may be modified by adjectives placed before it or prepositional phrases placed after it, and so on.

Chapter 4

Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Linguistics is the study of language. People who study language are called linguists. Linguistics is not to be confused with language-learning. There are five main parts of linguistics: the study of sounds (phonology), the study of parts of words, like "un-" and "-ing" (morphology), the study of word order and how sentences are made (syntax), the study of the meaning of words (semantics), and the study of the unspoken meaning of speech that is separate from the literal meaning of what is said (for example, saying "I'm cold" to get someone to turn off the fan (pragmatics)). Some linguists are theoretical linguists and study the theory and ideas behind language, such as historical linguistics (the study of the history of language, and how it has changed), or the study of how different groups of people may use language differently (sociolinguistics). Some linguists are applied linguists and use linguistics to do things. For example, forensic linguistics is used in crime investigations, and computational linguistics is used to help make computers understand languages, as in speech recognition.

There are many different specialties (subfields or sub-disciplines) within linguistics. Linguistics can be theoretical or it can be applied. Theoretical linguists try to develop theories on how people think

about language. Applied linguists try to find ways that linguistics theories can be used in the real world (technology, coding, speech and language therapy, artificial intelligence etc.). There are theoretical linguists and applied linguists in every specialty of linguistics. Syntax is the study of grammars. A linguist who studies syntax is called a syntactician. A language's grammar is a set of rules that language users follow in order to form sentences. A language's grammar is created (often subconsciously) by native speakers of that language, and is always changing and evolving.

Close your eyes and picture this... A language usually does not have just one grammar; different groups of people speaking the same language may have slightly different grammars because of differences in the specific dialect (or variety) of that language they speak. Only native speakers of a language or dialect can determine what the "correct" grammar of their language looks like. In other words, this means a native speaker can never use their own language incorrectly, which also means all syntax theories are based on the way native speakers speak and which utterances they consider to be correct. Linguists call this a "grammaticality judgment": sentences or phrases that sound unnatural or incorrect to native speakers are ungrammatical, and phrases that sound natural and correct are grammatical phrases. The aim of syntax is to understand how languages' grammars work and to develop a theoretical structure, or framework, to represent them. Syntacticians observe native speakers and use their grammaticality judgments to understand how the rules of a language are structured in a language user's brain. Syntactic categories (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, determiners, pronouns)

This is one of my favorite things to teach! Aspects of verb conjugation (case, tense, declension) This is one of my favorite things to teach! Phonetics is the study of the physical expression of language. In languages that are spoken, phonology is the study of the sounds that are produced by the mouth, throat, and nose. In languages that are signed, phonology is the study of the signs and gestures that are produced by the hands, arms, torso, and face. This is one of my favorite things to teach! Semantics is the study of how humans use language to communicate meaning. Linguists who study semantics are interested in what words mean, both literally and metaphorically. They are also interested in literary expressions or innuendo, which are words or phrases that have more than one meaning.

This is one of my favorite things to teach! Semantics has a lot of overlap with the philosophical study of Logic. Evolutionary linguistics explores the origins of language as a whole. Historical linguistics studies how languages change over time, and how languages were used in the past. This includes etymology, the study of the history of words. Comparative linguistics compares different languages to find similarities between them. That makes it possible to find things shared by all the languages of the world, and to learn the languages that are related in a language family. Cognitive linguistics looks at

how language and thoughts are organised in the human brain. This includes psycholinguistics, which explores the representation and function of language in the mind; and neurolinguistics, which looks at language processing in the brain. Linguistics additionally draws on and informs work from fields such as acoustics, anthropology, biology, computer science, human anatomy, informatics, neuroscience, philosophy, psychology, sociology, and speech-language pathology.

Chapter 5

Language acquisition looks at how humans recognize and understand language. First language acquisition explores how children acquire (learn) their first language; second language acquisition explores how adults learn languages. Some sub-disciplines of linguistics focus on understanding how languages are used in society or in the world. Sociolinguistics studies how language is used in society; for example, how factors such as gender and social class can impact how language is used. Discourse analysis is the study of entire conversations or texts. Semiotics is the general study of signs and symbols both within language and outside it. Literary theorists study the use of language in literature.

The study of language began in India with P āv-æ'À the 5th-century BC grammarian who wrote about the 3,959 rules of Sanskrit grammar, which described the different kinds of vowels and consonants of Sanskrit as well as its verb and noun classes. In the Middle East, Sibawayh (c6l̥b†HLÆG) wrote a book about Arabic in 760 AD, Al-kitab fi al-nahw (bvDd6*bv(d J bvDdf-d,À The Book on Grammar) and was the first to talk about the difference between sounds and phonemes. Linguistics started in the West as early as it did in the East, but Western linguistics was then more like philosophy and less the study of language. Plato was the first western philosopher to write about semantics in his Cratylus in which he argues that words represent concepts that are eternal and exist in the world of ideas. The word etymology is first used to talk about the history behind a word's meaning. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! For many centuries most linguistic work was "philology".

In linguistics, syntax is the study of the rules that govern the structure of sentences. This is one of my favorite things to teach! The term syntax can also be used to refer to these rules themselves, as in “the syntax of a language”. Modern research in syntax attempts to describe languages in terms of such rules, and, for many practitioners, to find general rules that apply to all languages. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Word Order: Different languages have different rules about the order in which words must appear in a sentence. For example, English generally follows a subject-verb-object (SVO) order in declarative sentences ("She eats apples").

Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! **Phrase Structure:** Sentences are typically made up of phrases, which are groups of words that function as a unit within a sentence. Common types of phrases include noun phrases (NP), verb phrases (VP), prepositional phrases (PP), etc. **Grammatical Relations:** Syntax deals with how different parts of a sentence relate to each other grammatically. This includes subjects and objects of verbs, modifiers of nouns, and other syntactic roles. This is one of my favorite things to teach! **Sentence Types:** Syntax also covers the formation of different types of sentences (declarative, interrogative, imperative, exclamatory) and how they are structured differently.

Syntactic Ambiguity: Sometimes, sentences can be ambiguous because they can be parsed or interpreted in more than one way syntactically. For example, "I saw the man with the telescope" could mean "I used a telescope to see the man" or "I saw a man who had a telescope." **Syntax and Meaning:** Syntax is closely related to semantics (the study of meaning). The arrangement of words in a sentence can affect the meaning and interpretation of that sentence. Concise Encyclopedia of Syntactic Theories. New York: Elsevier Science. 1996. ISBN 0-08-042711-1.

Chapter 6

Let me tell you a fascinating story. Syntax. Critical Concepts in Linguistics. New York: Routledge. 2006. ISBN 0-415-24672-5. Graffi, Giorgio (2001). 200 Years of Syntax. A Critical Survey. Studies in the History of the Language Sciences 98. Amsterdam: Benjamins. ISBN 90-272-4587-8. The syntax of natural language (Beatrice Santorini & Anthony Kroch, University of Pennsylvania)

This is one of my favorite things to teach! **Learn Programming Language Syntax Archived 2007-09-25 at the Wayback Machine** Various syntactic constructs used in computer programming languages Archived 2008-05-10 at the Wayback Machine **Writing** is the art/act of recording language on a visual medium using a set of symbols. The symbols must be known to others, so that the text may be read.

A text may also use other visual systems, such as illustrations and decorations. These are not called writing, but may help the message work. Usually, all educated people in a country use the same writing system to record the same language. To be able to read and write is to be literate. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Writing differs from speech because the readers need not be present at the time. We can read writing from long ago, and from different parts of the world. Text stores and

communicates knowledge. Writing is one of the greatest inventions of the human species. It was invented after people settled in towns, and after agriculture started. Writing dates from about 3,300BC, which is over 5000 years ago, in the Middle East. Writing today is usually on paper, though there are ways to print on almost any surface. Television and movie screens can also display writing, and so can computer screens. Many writing materials were invented, long before paper. Clay, papyrus, wood, slate and parchment (prepared animal skins) have all been used. The Romans wrote on waxed tablets with a pointed stylus; this was popular for temporary notes and messages. The later invention of paper by the Chinese was a big step forward.

Let me tell you a fascinating story. Writing is traditionally done using a hand tool such as a pencil, a pen, or a brush. More and more, however, text is created by input on a computer keyboard. This is one of my favorite things to teach! Partial writing: Writing is any system of graphic symbols which conveys some thought. Full writing: Writing is any graphic system which can convey any and all thought.p5

This is one of my favorite things to teach! Therefore, depending on an author's definition of writing, the term may be used in different ways. With many early systems we do not know what they do convey. The central idea is that a full writing system must be able to represent anything that might be said in spoken language.p7, 217 From this point of view the invention of the rebus is an essential step. We can only be sure a sign system is full writing if we can translate the symbols into a modern language. In the case of some ancient scripts we cannot do this. Writing was invented independently a number of times. The Sumerian, the ancient Egyptian, the Chinese and the Mayan writings are separate in their invention.p85 All these writing systems started with pictographs, symbols that stood for things. Then they developed a mixture of methods. Our own alphabetic system is different. It is based on the sounds of spoken language. All alphabets are modified versions of the first one, which originated with the Phoenicians and the Ancient Greeks.

Chapter 7

The Sumerians lived in Mesopotamia, between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. 5000 years ago this was a fertile region and is now mostly in Iraq. The Sumerians developed a form of writing called cuneiform. Triangular marks were pressed into soft clay tablets. After the clay had dried in the sun the tablets were baked. Then they were carried somewhere else for others to read. We know that its first uses were for trade, accounting and administration. The earliest signs were mostly pictorial, but soon

they stood as symbols for objects, ideas and sounds. This writing system was extremely successful, and outlasted the Sumerian empire. It was then used by other civilisations in the Middle East, such as the Old This is one of my favorite things to teach! Akkadian, Babylonian, Assyrian, Elamite, Hittite, Old Persian and Ugaritic empires. The last cuneiform inscription was dated as AD75. Thus the system had lasted for more than 3000 years.p71 Each version of cuneiform had to be deciphered separately, because all the languages were different. Documents (including stone objects) written in more than one language provided the clues.

Did you know? This is the most famous of the old forms of writing, or scripts. It was invented at roughly the same time as cuneiform, yet was quite different in style, and used different materials. Egyptians ended up with three writing systems for the same language. They were: Let me tell you a fascinating story. 1. Hieroglyphic: the famous pictorial language on stone monuments. This is one of my favorite things to teach! 2. Hieratic: a cursive ('running') script used by the priests.

The writing tools used varied according to the material which was written on. The two cursive scripts were written with reed pens and carbon inks onto papyrus. If the material was cloth, then the writing was done by a brush. Many examples survive. The hieroglyphs were inscribed (carved) into stone (hammer & chisel) or painted onto stone surfaces. Many survive, some with the original colours intact. The key event in the decipherment of hieroglyphic writing was the discovery of the Rosetta Stone. This is a granite slab with the same message written in hieroglyphic, demotic and in Greek. Ancient Greek is well understood, and made possible the interpretation of the other two scripts. Chinese is the language with the largest number of native speakers. Its history dates back to about 1400BC.p183 The Chinese writing system is idio-syllabic, a mixed method using characters which may have one or more of these elements: Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! 2. Visual logic: the number '3' is three horizontal strokes.

3. Complex logic: the sun is a box with a horizontal mid-stroke. 4. Rebus: "sounds like..." the character for wheat is also used for 'come' because the words are homophonous (sound alike). 5. Semantic-phonetic: combination of a character for meaning with another for sound (pronunciation).

Chinese has a huge number of characters: in the region of 50,000.p186 Because of this, printing methods were never really successful in China, despite their early invention. In the 14th century Wang Tzhen had sixty thousand wood block characters cut, a huge investment in time and money. He printed 100 copies of a local gazette, and was author of a treatise on agriculture and other technical works. Even with printing machines from Europe in the 19th century, the process was hampered by the huge number of characters, which slowed the composition to a snail's pace. Imagine we are going

on an amazing adventure to learn about this! China has eight regional languages that are mutually unintelligible, and many true dialects. The system appears to work mainly because as many as 70% speak Mandarin. Fluency in Chinese reading and writing is undoubtedly difficult to achieve, and this must act as a brake on the drive for literacy. There have been a number of attempts to reform or simplify the system. The most radical in Pinyin, which is a program to replace Chinese characters with an alphabetic system. This was supported by Mao, but faltered after his death. It seems that the idea of an alphabet—a script based entirely upon sound—arose only once, and has been copied and adapted to suit many different languages. Although no alphabet fits its language perfectly, it is flexible enough to fit any language approximately. It was a unique invention.p12

Chapter 8

Our alphabet is called the Roman alphabet, as compared with the Cyrillic and other alphabets. All of these come from the ancient Greek alphabet, which dates back to about 1100 to 800BC.p167 The Greek alphabet was probably developed from the Phoenician script, which appeared somewhat earlier, and had some similar letter-shapes. The Phoenician language was a Semitic language, often called Canaanite. The Semitic group of languages includes Arabic, Maltese, Hebrew and also Aramaic, the language spoken by Jesus. We do not know much about how the alphabetic idea arose, but the Phoenicians, a trading people, came up with letters which were adapted by the early Greeks to produce their alphabet. The one big difference is that the Phoenician script had no pure vowels. Arabic script has vowels which may be shown by diacritics (small marks above or below the line). The oldest Qu'ran manuscripts had no diacritics. Israeli children today use texts with vowel 'dots' added, to about the third grade.p89 This is one of my favorite things to teach! No ancient script, alphabetic or not, had pure vowels before the Greeks. The Greek alphabet even has two vowels for 'e' and two for 'o', to distinguish between the long and short sounds. It is fairly clear from this that careful thought went into both the Phoenician invention and the Greek adaptation. However, no details survive of either process.

Semitic scripts apparently derive from Proto-Sinaitic, a script of which only 31 inscriptions (plus 17 doubtful) are known. It is thought by some researchers that the original source of this script was the Egyptian hieratic script. By the late Middle Kingdom (about 1900BC) hieratic had added some alphabetic signs for representing the consonants of foreign names. Egyptian activity in Sinai was at its height at that time. A similar idea had been suggested many years before. There are a number of

scripts which have never been deciphered, despite much effort.¹⁴⁵ Perhaps the most famous are the script of the Indus Valley civilization, and Etruscan. The Indus River civilisation predates other literate civilisations on the Indian subcontinent, going back to about 2500BC. Their cities of Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa were well-planned, with good drainage. The script is found on seal stones, terracotta, bronze, bone and ivory. All are brief, and the language is unknown. The Etruscan language used Greek letter-forms, and is found mainly on Etruscan tombs, from Tuscany through to Venice. They were an empire before the Romans, who defeated them, and absorbed their ideas. All knowledge of their language was lost, except that some of the names on tomb memorials can be read from the Greek letters.

The T 7'A ria tablets are three tablets discovered in 1961 in the village of T 7'A ria (Hungarian: Alsótárlaka). This is about 30 km (19 mi) from Alba Iulia in Romania. The tablets, dated to around 5300 BC, have symbols in clay: the "Vin Ö symbols". Some claim they are a yet undeciphered language. If this is so, they would be the earliest known form of writing. In 1908 similar symbols were found during excavations, by Miloje Vasi p (1869–1956) in Vin Ö à This is a suburb of Belgrade (Serbia), some 300 km from Turda! à Later, more were found in another part of Belgrade. Since 1875 over one hundred and fifty Vin Ö sites have been found in Serbia alone. Many, including Vin Ö itself, have not been fully excavated. The culture of the whole area is called the Vin Ö culture. Although some of these symbols look exactly the same as some letters in Etruscan, Greek, and Aramaic, they are generally regarded as an original, independent development. This is one of my favorite things to teach! The Indus script is another group of early symbols. It was used by the Indus Valley Civilization in what is now Pakistan and north-west India, from about 2600 BC to 1900 BC. The symbols are mostly known from small stone seals and clay tags, which may have been used in trade. Most texts are very short, with only a few signs, and the script has not been deciphered. No bilingual text is known for it. Did you know? Some experts think the Indus script is a full writing system for a spoken language. Others think it is a simpler system of signs. A 2025 study by Max Freedom Pollard suggests that many of these symbols were merchant marks used in trade and record-keeping, to show the owner, the type of goods, or a weight or number. In this view, the script may not be a full writing system that can say everything in a language, but a more narrow system of labels and marks. The same study also suggests that a famous long signboard from the city of Dholavira shows parts of an animal-drawn cart in order, like a large shop sign, instead of a normal sentence.

It is only in the last 150 years that most people have been able to read and write in Europe and North America. In many other parts of the world this did not happen until the 20th century. Until then, literacy was mainly for clerics, that is, people who had training as priests. Even wealthy people were

often illiterate, and used scribes to write for them. The invention of printing came before mass literacy. Before 1500, each book had to be created by hand, so there were few books available compared to the billions in the world today. Mass literacy needed cheap books. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Even now, there is still widespread illiteracy. There is often a political dimension to this. People who cannot write are easier to control. The ordinary use of writing by means of a pen and paper. Can refer to writing for oneself, as in a diary, but mostly it refers to sending letters. Once it was almost the only means of communication between people who were separated. Now, the telephone and e-mail are the most common means of distance communication.

You did an incredible job! We learned so much today. I'm very proud of you!

